

693
LWE cadres killed by Greyhounds

63
Greyhounds killed in the line of duty

19,000
Police/security personnel from other states and central forces trained by Greyhounds

2026: With India officially declared free of LWE, Telangana moves to redeploy about half of its Greyhounds personnel to other police departments

strength for field operations, maintenance and training, with a review every few months.

For some commandos, the transition comes after decades spent in the force. Md Abbas (*name changed*), now 54, joined Greyhounds in 1997, when Naxalism was at its peak, and has spent almost his entire service with the unit. He is currently deployed at the Greyhounds base near Hyderabad. One of his colleagues, with 20 years in the force, says pride in being a Greyhound does not mean resistance to redeployment. "We are not sentimentally attached to insist on being [commandos] forever, especially when the mission is accomplished," he says.

The officer recalls a short-lived phase in the 1990s when the People's War Group had been reduced to a single armed *dalam*, or team, in Andhra. It appeared that the insurgency was close to being extinguished. Instead, the militants went underground, regrouped and expanded their recruitment. "The Maoist influence later stretched from Pasupati in Nepal to Tirupati. So, we cannot be totally relaxed now," he adds. About 1,200 Greyhounds commandos remain in active duty in the state, supported by around 300 SIB personnel, while OCTOPUS has about 480 commandos.

At the same time, the physical infrastructure associated with the old conflict is beginning to acquire new possibilities. The Telangana government plans to develop the rugged hills of Karreguttalu in Mulugu district along the Chhattisgarh border—the last major Maoist bastion in the state to fall to security forces earlier this year—as a tourist destination, with roads and other infrastructure. In Andhra Pradesh, the Naidu government is reportedly considering redeveloping the Greyhounds' training and operations base on a hill near Visakhapatnam as a large convention centre with hotels or an IT park. A new base and training centre is expected to be established in neighbouring Vizianagaram district, a senior IPS officer tells INDIA TODAY.

The Greyhounds' next chapter, then, is unlikely to follow a single arc. The larger challenge will be to preserve the skills, discipline and institutional memory that made the force formidable, while putting its specialised manpower to work against the new threats on the frontline. ■

ANDHRA PRADESH IS TAKING A MORE CAUTIOUS APPROACH, WITH CM CHANDRABABU NAIDU HIMSELF HAVING SURVIVED A MAJOR MAOIST ASSASSINATION BID NEAR TIRUPATI IN 2003

their educational qualifications and backgrounds and interviewed before being assigned new responsibilities. "The objective is to make the best, optimal use of the available police manpower in areas that directly affect the lives and safety of people," he says. A specialised training programme at the Telangana Police Academy was also conducted to familiarise the commandos with their new departments. In Hyderabad, some were deployed at road junctions for traffic regulation as part of their acclimatisation to their new responsibilities. They were even counselled to prepare them for the transition.

Dr Anil Kumar, DGP (Operations), Greyhounds & OCTOPUS, stresses that the reassignment does not amount to abandoning the force's original purpose. Over 650 personnel will continue to serve in the anti-Maoist force. "We are not lowering our guard against Maoism," Kumar says. Both Greyhounds and OCTOPUS, he says, will retain sufficient

"Some of our colleagues have been redeployed, we are here. If tomorrow, the bosses decide our requirement is somewhere else, we will go and serve there too with the same commitment we imbibed here."

ANDHRA'S CAUTION

Andhra Pradesh is taking a more conservative approach, with chief minister Chandrababu Naidu himself having survived a major assassination bid near Tirupati in 2003. On October 1 that year, Maoists triggered claymore landmine blasts targeting his convoy, leaving the then CM of undivided Andhra Pradesh with a fractured collarbone and other injuries.

A senior IPS officer with extensive Greyhounds experience says there is no immediate plan to scale down the state's Greyhounds, SIB or OCTOPUS units. "Yes, Maoist activity is non-existent now, but it is still too early to fold up or even downsize the elite combat units," the officer says.